

LEON GAWENDA

Ph.D. Candidate and Research Associate
Bielefeld University (Faculty of Sociology)

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

My current PhD research investigates ‘politics of place’ and their history. I study spatial patterns of political participation and geographical representation. I rely on electoral data, survey data, and parliamentary speech data using quantitative methods.

EDUCATION

Bielefeld University since Sep 2024

- PhD candidate in Sociology, supervisors: Martin Kroh & Lukas Haffert
- Research associate at the Leibniz Science Campus, SOEP RegioHub

Tübingen University 2021 – 2024

- M.A. Public Policy & Social Change
- Stay abroad at Sciences Po, Aix-en-Provence (FR)
- Thesis: Environmental issue salience and policy support

Passau University 2017 – 2021

- B.A. Governance & Public Policy

CURRENT PROJECTS

Explaining historical persistence in Germany’s electoral geography across 130 years
under review

An old divider? A historical comparison of urban-rural partisan polarisation across Western democracies

Working paper with Twan Huijsmans

Local and familial transmission of partisanship and religion: explaining the persistence of religious voting

Working paper

Who speaks for the left-behind? Framing of spatial inequalities in parliamentary speeches

Working paper with Chen Zeng and Konstantin Wandel

Environmental issue salience and policy support

Working paper

CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

EPSS 2026, Belfast	Jun 2026
Conference on the Political Dimensions of Urban and Rural Lives, LSE	Apr 2026
AK Wahlen Jahrestagung*, Free University Berlin	Sep 2025
EPOP Annual Conference 2025, Exeter University	Sep 2025
Workshop on Political Behaviour in Central and Eastern Europe, EUI Florence	Jun 2025

* only attendance

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Tübingen University

- Tutorial for "Methods of policy evaluation: panel analysis and quasi-experiments" (Graduate)
- Tutorial for "Introduction to quantitative analysis" (Undergraduate)

SKILLS

Statistical analysis R (advanced), Stata (basics), LaTeX (basics)

Languages German, English (fluent), Spanish (advanced), French (basic)